

Project Journal

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Section: BCS22

Entry # 2

Date Range: April 9 – April 17, 2026

1. Current Progress & Goals

What was your main objective for this week? Briefly describe the tasks you completed.

- This week, I worked on adding user accounts to our movie app so people can save their favorite movies and see them again later, even if they close the browser.
- I created a simple database to store user info and save movies.
- I wrote code that lets users sign up, log in, and log out safely.
- I connected the "heart" button on movie cards to the database, so when you click it, the movie gets saved to your account.
- I updated the app to check if you're logged in when the page loads and show your saved movies if you are.

2. Challenges & Roadblocks

Did you encounter any technical issues, lack of resources, or changes in your plan? Be specific.

- The database wanted genres as a simple text list (like "Action,Comedy"), but my app used arrays. I had to learn how to convert between the two formats.
- I was worried about security like, what if someone tries to hack the login? I learned to use `password_hash()` so passwords are never stored as plain text.
- Sometimes the app would try to load favorites before knowing if the user was logged in, which caused errors. I fixed this by making the app check login status first.

3. Problem Solving & Pivots

How did you address the challenges mentioned above? What did you learn?

- I broke big tasks into small steps: first make the database, then make login work, then connect the save button. This made debugging easier.
- I used simple helper functions in PHP (like `respond()` and `requireLogin()`) so I didn't have to repeat the same code over and over.

- I tested each part separately: first I checked if the database saved a user, then if login worked, then if favorites showed up. Testing small pieces helped me find mistakes faster.
- Biggest lesson: when building features that involve user data, always think "What if something goes wrong?" and add simple error messages so users aren't left confused.

4. Discussion of Next Steps

Based on your progress today, what are your specific and achievable goals for the next session?

- Add a simple "Forgot password?" option so users can reset their login if they forget.
- Make the login box look nicer and match the rest of the app's design.
- Add a small animation or message when a movie is saved, so users get instant feedback.
- Test the app on a phone to make sure login and favorites work well on smaller screens.
- Write down simple instructions for teammates on how to set up the database on their own computers.